11-Year-Old Bodhana Makes Chess History

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-10-29 5 min read

Imagine becoming one of the world's top chess players before finishing middle school! For Bodhana Sivanandan, an 11-year-old from northwest London, England, this is already a reality. On September 26, 2026, she became the youngest person ever to earn the **Woman Grandmaster** title. The record was previously held by Kateryna Lagno, who was 12 when she won it in 2002.

The **Woman Grandmaster** title is one of the highest honors in chess. To earn it, a player must reach a **rating** of at least 2,300 points through strong performances in official matches, and meet certain requirements in three qualifying tournaments to achieve what are called **norms**.

Bodhana's journey began during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, when she was five years old. A friend of her father gave the family a bag of toys and books. Inside, Bodhana discovered a chessboard and became curious about the game. Her father encouraged her to learn, and she quickly developed a passion for it.

Her talent showed early. At age seven, she won all 24 of her games at the European Schools Championship, earning three gold medals. Two years later, she was selected to represent England at the 2024 Chess **Olympiad** in Hungary, the youngest person ever to compete for England in any international sporting competition. In 2025, at just 10 years old, she became the youngest girl to beat a Grandmaster, Peter Wells, in a **classical** game at the British Chess Championships.

In August 2026, she became the youngest-ever British women's chess champion. The following month, at the 46th Chess **Olympiad** in Samarkand as England's top player, she played all 11 rounds of the tournament, winning six games, drawing four, and losing just one. That performance earned her the third and final norm, completing her record-breaking title. Bodhana hopes to eventually earn the Grandmaster title, which is open to players of any gender. When not playing chess, she is a regular middle school student who enjoys playing the piano and violin, as well as reading.

Word Treasure

Woman Grandmaster -- It is a high chess title earned through strong play in official tournaments.

rating -- A rating is a number that shows how strong a chess player has been in matches.

norms -- Norms are strong results a player must achieve in qualifying tournaments to earn a title.

classical -- A classical game is a chess game played with a long time limit, not a quick game.

Olympiad -- The Chess Olympiad is a large team chess event where players compete for their countries.

Background you need

Chess is a board game in which players move different pieces across a board, trying to trap the other player's king.

Players earn titles by doing well in official tournaments over time, and a rating shows how strong a player has been against other players.

Big team events bring players from different countries together to play for their national teams, and winning at a young age is rare because chess rewards long practice and careful thinking.

Break it down

LEAD: Bodhana Sivanandan, 11, becomes the youngest person ever to earn the Woman Grandmaster title.

KEY EVENT: The title is completed at the 46th Chess Olympiad in Samarkand.

+- WHO: Bodhana Sivanandan, England's top player.

+- WHEN: On September 26, 2026, after playing all 11 rounds.

+- RESULT: She won six games, drew four, and lost one, earning her third and final norm.

BACKGROUND: How the title is earned and Bodhana's early rise in chess.

+- TITLE RULES: A rating of at least 2,300 points and norms in three qualifying tournaments.

+- EARLY START: She discovered a chessboard at age five during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020.

+- EARLY WINS: At seven she won all 24 games at the European Schools Championship; at 10 she beat Grandmaster Peter Wells.

WHAT NEXT: Bodhana hopes to earn the Grandmaster title, open to players of any gender.

Why it matters

Bodhana's record shows how far young talent can go with early encouragement and steady practice, and it may inspire more young players, especially girls, to take up competitive chess.

Test what you remember

1. What title did Bodhana Sivanandan become the youngest person ever to earn?

- (A) The British women's chess champion title
- (B) The Grandmaster title
- (C) The European Schools champion title
- (D) The Woman Grandmaster title

2. What rating must a player reach to earn the Woman Grandmaster title?

- (A) At least 2,300 points
- (B) At least 2,500 points
- (C) At least 2,000 points
- (D) At least 1,800 points

3. What did Bodhana do at the European Schools Championship at age seven?

- (A) She drew four games and lost one
- (B) She won three gold medals in Hungary
- (C) She beat a Grandmaster in a classical game
- (D) She won all 24 of her games

4. Who did Bodhana beat at age 10 at the British Chess Championships?

- (A) England's top player
- (B) Peter Wells
- (C) Kateryna Lagno
- (D) A player from Samarkand

5. What was Bodhana's result at the 46th Chess Olympiad in Samarkand?

- (A) She won all 11 rounds
- (B) She won four games, drew six, and lost one
- (C) She won six games and drew five
- (D) She won six games, drew four, and lost one

6. Who previously held the record for youngest Woman Grandmaster?

- (A) Kateryna Lagno, who was 12 when she won it in 2002
- (B) Peter Wells
- (C) The youngest British women's chess champion
- (D) Bodhana Sivanandan

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):